

# M02: Do you speak bad English?



1. **Pre-watching brainstorming:** 🏰 Imagine this: Queen Victoria (reigned 1837-1901) visits you in a dream and declares that you will be the ruler of the English language – for one day only. During this day, you have the power to decide:

- What rules (if any) should be followed when speaking or writing English
- Which variety or speaker(s) the rules should be based on (e.g. region, social class, profession, genre, etc.)
- Who should make decisions about English in the future—will there be a council, a single authority, or complete freedom?

Write down your plan or discuss it in pairs. Consider:

- Would you simplify or change any grammar or spelling rules?
- Would you give priority to any one variety of English (e.g. British, American, Nigerian, Singaporean, ...)?
- Would you allow more than one “standard”?
- Who should decide how English evolves after your day of power ends?

Optional Extension: Give your version of English a name (e.g. Global English, RealTalk, Queen's Remix).

**2. While-watching checklist:** Watch the TEDx talk “2 Billion Voices: How to speak bad English perfectly” by Heather Hansen until minute 13:00 While doing so, answer the following questions:

| Statement                                                                       | ✓ / x |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| Language can be a tool of division, showing who ‘belongs’ and who does not.     | +     |
| Heather Hansen is a native speaker of English.                                  | +     |
| Most English conversations happen between non-native speakers.                  | +     |
| Teaching of English follows the idea that English needs to be ‘perfect’.        | +     |
| Grammar is more important than pronunciation in international communication.    | +     |
| There are 5x as many non-native (ESL/EFL) speakers than native (ENL) speakers.  | -     |
| Heather believes native speakers are the best models for communication.         | -     |
| Misunderstandings <u>d</u> ecrease when native speakers enter a conversation.   | -     |
| Adaptability is more important than correctness – in speaking and listening.    | +     |
| Speaking Global English means adjusting to your listeners.                      | +     |
| People often judge others’ intelligence based on how they speak English.        | +     |
| The th sound is important for international communication.                      | -     |
| English is the native language of most people who speak it today.               | -     |
| International communication is usually more successful between native speakers. | +     |
| Heather once helped a client reduce their accent completely.                    | -     |

**Analysis:** Analyze the story below (unfortunately an urban myth, not factual) from the perspective of intercultural communication and lingua franca English. Taking notes on the most important points is sufficient – no full sentences required!



Yoshirō Mori 2008      With Obama      Yoshirō Mori 2018

### English is a difficult language for some!

Prime Minister Mori was given some basic English conversation training before he visited Washington to meet president Barack Obama.

The instructor told Prime Minister Mori "When you shake hands with President Obama, please ask 'How are you?'. Then Mr. Obama should say, 'I am fine, and you?' Now, you should say 'me too'. Afterwards we, translators, will do the work for you.'

It looked quite simple, but the truth is when Mori met Obama, he mistakenly said 'Who are you?', instead of 'How are you?'. Mr. Obama was a bit shocked but still managed to react with humor: 'Well, I'm Michelle's husband, ha-ha.' Then Mori replied 'me too, ha-ha.' Then there was a long silence in the meeting room.

### 3. Post-watching reflection:

- (1) Add any new concepts, words and expressions into your mindmap. (Potential title “‘Bad’ English”)
- (2) Reflect on the following questions and write a short essay on your thoughts.
  - What are your main takeaways from the lecture?
  - (How) Did it impact the way you regard English class?
  - (How) Did it change the way you look at other’s ‘bad’ English?
  - Do you (want to) speak bad English perfectly? What would others need to do?

If you have time, watch the rest of the lecture to add further ideas.

### 4. Write a blog entry on Xiaoma’s speech

Before continuing, watch [Xiaoma’s speech](#) (2:50 – 5:30 (or longer, if you like), given at Westtown Highschool earlier this year on the occasion of languages week.

New generations of speakers always invent their own ways of speaking – pronunciation, slang, phrases, and ways of expressing themselves. As these speakers grow older, they bring this language with them: into school, the workplace, and eventually into how they raise their own children. So, as Xiaoma puts it:

*“You’re legit patching the English language DLC with fresh updates, literally shifting the English meta. ... And honestly, your memes today finna hit as the textbook vocab of tomorrow; bet! ... your casual pookie talk could soon be the dictionary definition”.*

Do you agree? Should this kind of language be accepted as part of “real English”? What does this say about how language changes — and who controls it?

Write a **blog entry** in which you (language and structure support on next page):

- Share your personal opinion on this statement.
- Give examples of how language is changing around you (e.g. slang, online trends, accents, text language).
- Reflect on what this means for schools, dictionaries, or the idea of “proper English”.
- Speak directly to your readers — be personal, honest, and reflective.
- Include the terms from the **glossary** as much as you can.

**Tone:** informal, thoughtful, creative — like something you’d read on a student blog.

**Length suggestion:** around 200 words.

## Language and structure support

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|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>Title suggestion:</b><br/><i>"From Memes to the Dictionary? My Thoughts on Language Change"</i></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <p><b>Introduction – Hook your readers:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Have you ever used a word like <i>slay</i>, <i>sus</i>, or <i>pookie</i> — and your teacher had no idea what it meant?</li> <li>• Language changes all the time — especially with each new generation. But should those changes be accepted as “real” English?</li> </ul> |
| <p><b>Paragraph 1 – State your opinion:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• In my opinion, ...</li> <li>• I believe that language change is...</li> <li>• When I read the quote <i>“your memes today finna hit as the textbook vocab of tomorrow”</i>, I thought...</li> </ul>                                                                                                        | <p><b>Paragraph 2 – Give examples of language change:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• A good example of this is...</li> <li>• On social media, people often say...</li> <li>• In my group of friends, we say things like...</li> <li>• These phrases might sound strange to adults, but for us...</li> </ul>                                      |
| <p><b>Paragraph 3 – Reflect on school, “proper English”, and dictionaries:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Some people think slang should stay out of the classroom, but I think...</li> <li>• It’s interesting that dictionaries sometimes add words like...</li> <li>• What really is “correct” English, anyway?</li> <li>• Teachers and schools should/shouldn’t...</li> </ul> | <p><b>Paragraph 4 – Conclusion / final thoughts:</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• To sum up, I think it’s important to remember that...</li> <li>• Language belongs to everyone — and that means...</li> <li>• Maybe one day, our “pookie talk” really will be in the dictionary — and honestly, I think that’s...</li> </ul>                      |